

The Value Story Template

Build a "You pay X, you get Y, you keep Z" story for any product - one page, customer-ready.

Why most value stories fail

They talk about the product. A value story that works talks about the customer's P&L. If procurement can't re-explain your story to their CFO in one sentence, you don't have a value story - you have a brochure.

The skeleton (fill the brackets)

1. THE OUTCOME UNIT	The unit your customer already thinks in: EUR/ha, EUR/hour of uptime, EUR/unit produced. Never your product unit. <i>Write yours: _____</i>
2. YOU PAY X	The full price, stated without apology. Anchored next to the value, never alone. <i>"You invest [X] per [unit]..."</i>
3. YOU GET Y	The quantified outcomes, in THEIR numbers: "[driver 1] worth [EUR], [driver 2] worth [EUR], [risk avoided] worth [EUR]". Use their yields, their labor costs, their downtime records. 2-4 drivers max.
4. YOU KEEP Z	The customer surplus: Y minus X. This is their reason to say yes. If Z is zero, the deal doesn't close - by design, always leave visible value on the table.
5. THE PROOF	One evidence line per driver: field trial, their own records, reference customer. A claim without proof is a discount request waiting to happen.

Worked example (crop protection, EUR/ha)

"You invest 57 EUR/ha - 12 EUR more than the standard. You get: one application avoided (12 EUR/ha, your own labor records), +2% yield protection (19 EUR/ha at your average yield and price), and a longer protection window that cuts re-spray risk (4 EUR/ha). That's 35 EUR/ha of value for 12 EUR of premium - you keep 23 EUR/ha. Here's the trial data from your region."

Dos

- Fill the numbers WITH the customer where possible - people don't argue with their own data.
- State the price confidently inside the story. A price whispered separately invites attack.
- Keep it under 60 seconds spoken. If it needs a slide deck, it's not a story yet.
- Rebuild per segment - the same product carries different value for different customers.

Don'ts

- Don't count value the customer can't verify - one attacked number poisons the whole story.
- Don't capture 100% of the value. Zero customer surplus = zero deals.

- Don't mention your costs. Ever. The story is about their outcomes, not your margin.
- Don't blindly trust AI-generated value numbers - draft with AI, verify against real data, own the output.

Pair this with the Willingness-to-Pay Calculator (xlsx) to quantify the drivers before writing the story.